

Home Decor Collection

Move up from small pieces to coasters, trays, wall art, and small river-style tables — and learn to control heat buildup so a big pour cures clear instead of cracking.

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SECTION 1

Coasters & Trays: Your First Large Pour

By the end of this section you'll know how to pour a flat, bubble-free coaster or tray and get it level while it cures.

Coasters and trays are the natural next step up from jewelry: bigger surface area, a flat open mold instead of a deep cavity, and a bigger premium on getting the surface perfectly level.

Step by step

- 1 Level your workspace first, not after.** Set your mold on a surface you've checked with a level, then shim it with folded cardboard or a leveling tool until it reads flat in both directions. Resin finds the low point and pools there while it's still liquid.
- 2 Mix in the ratio on your label.** Measure resin and hardener by volume in the ratio printed on your resin's bottle (many art resins run 1:1, but follow the exact ratio on YOUR resin's label — ratios vary by brand) and mix slowly for the full time it calls for, scraping the sides and bottom of the cup.
- 3 Pour in one steady layer for a single coaster.** For a coaster under about 1/4 in (6 mm) thick, pour the full depth at once rather than in layers — thin pours cure cooler and are less prone to the cracking that affects thick pours (more on that in Section 4).
- 4 Torch the surface once, lightly.** One or two quick passes with a torch or heat gun a few inches (5-8 cm) above the surface pops bubbles. Re-check level immediately after, since moving the mold can tip it.
- 5 Cover and leave it undisturbed.** Tent it against dust and don't touch, tilt, or blow on it for at least the first few hours of cure — any disturbance during the gel stage can leave a permanent texture or wave in the surface.



Do it this way

Pour a few millimeters of resin and let it skin over slightly before adding any heavier decorative elements (shells, pressed botanicals) on a tray — this stops them from sinking straight to the bottom.

Common mistake

Walking away before checking level a second time. Molds shift slightly as you set them down after pouring — always re-check level in the first few minutes, while the resin is still liquid enough to self-correct.

PIECE	TYPICAL POUR DEPTH	CURE TIME TO HANDLE (CHECK YOUR LABEL)
Coaster	1/4 in (6 mm)	18-24 hrs
Serving tray	1/8-1/4 in (3-6 mm) over wood	24-48 hrs
Deep bowl or dish	Multiple thin layers	Add 24 hrs per layer

SECTION 2

Resin Art Panels & Wall Pieces

By the end of this section you'll know how to pour a resin art panel on a wood or canvas base that hangs flat and doesn't drip off the edges.

A resin art panel is really a two-part job: sealing and prepping the base so resin doesn't soak in unevenly, and controlling the edge so your pour doesn't run down the side of the panel onto your table.

Step by step

- 1 Seal porous bases first.** Wood and raw canvas both release trapped air when resin hits them, which shows up as tiny bubbles on the surface. Brush on a thin "seal coat" of resin (or a dedicated sealer) and let it cure before your main color pour.
- 2 Build an edge dam.** Tape the back and sides of a wood panel with painter's tape that sits slightly higher than the panel edge, or use a cradled panel with a raised lip, so resin doesn't run off the sides.
- 3 Mix your colors in separate cups.** Divide your main batch into cups and tint each with mica powder, liquid pigment, or alcohol ink before pouring — mix color in fully before it touches the panel, not after.
- 4 Pour your base layer, then build color on top.** Pour a thin base coat, then add tinted resin in the pattern you want (puddles, lines, cells) and use a heat gun in short bursts to blend colors and pop bubbles without overheating any one spot.
- 5 Trim the drips after curing.** Once fully cured, carefully trim any resin that crept past your tape dam with a sharp utility blade or fine sandpaper, then wet-sand the edge smooth.



Safety first

Work in a ventilated room with a window or fan pulling fumes away from you, wear nitrile gloves (not latex — resin degrades latex), and wear eye protection any time you're using a heat gun or torch near an open resin surface.

Checklist: before you pour a panel

- ☐ Base is sealed and fully cured (if wood or canvas)
- ☐ Edge dam (tape or lip) is in place and pressed down tight
- ☐ Panel is level and in a dust-free, ventilated space
- ☐ Colors are pre-mixed in labeled cups before you start pouring

SECTION 3

Small River Tables Without the Guesswork

By the end of this section you'll know how a small-scale river table differs from a flat pour and how to avoid the two mistakes that sink most first attempts.

A "river table" is a wood slab (or two) with a resin-filled gap down the middle. At small scale — a side table or charcuterie-board size — the two things that matter most are sealing the wood and pouring in layers instead of all at once.

Step by step

- 1 Choose kiln-dried wood.** Wood with high moisture content will release that moisture into the resin as bubbles or cause the bond to fail later. Kiln-dried or well-seasoned wood is worth the extra cost at this scale.
- 2 Build a dam that actually seals.** Use silicone caulk or hot glue along every seam of your melamine or acrylic dam boards, pressed firmly against the wood — any gap, even a hairline one, will leak resin.
- 3 Seal the wood edges facing the resin.** Brush a thin seal coat of resin onto the wood edges that will touch the river and let it cure, exactly like you would for a panel base — this stops bubbles rising out of the wood grain during the main pour.
- 4 Pour in layers, not all at once.** For a river deeper than about 1/2 in (12 mm), pour in layers roughly 1/4-1/2 in (6-12 mm) at a time, letting each one cure most of the way before adding the next. This is the single biggest factor in whether a deep pour cures clear or cracks (see Section 4).
- 5 Sand and flatten after full cure.** Once every layer has fully cured, sand the surface flat across both the wood and resin with a random-orbit sander and rising grits, then apply a wood finish of your choice to the wood sections only.



Do it this way

Start your first river project at coffee-table or lap-desk size, not a full dining table — the layering and dam-sealing skills transfer directly once you've proven them small.

RIVER DEPTH	APPROACH	WHY
Under 1/2 in (12 mm)	Single pour	Low enough mass to cure safely
1/2-2 in (12-50 mm)	2-4 layers	Keeps heat buildup manageable per layer
Over 2 in (50 mm)	Deep-pour resin, by label instructions	Standard art resin is not rated for single deep pours

SECTION 4

Managing Exotherm on Big Pours

By the end of this section you'll understand why thick resin pours overheat and crack, and the concrete steps that keep a big piece curing clear.

"Exotherm" just means the heat that resin naturally gives off as it cures. In a thin coaster, that heat escapes into the air fast enough to never be a problem. In a thick tray, panel edge, or river layer, the heat can't escape fast enough, the center gets hot enough to boil micro-bubbles into the resin, discolor it yellow-amber, or crack it as it cools unevenly.

Step by step

- 1 Respect your resin's maximum pour depth.** Every resin label states a maximum thickness per pour — this is the single most important number for avoiding exotherm problems. Standard art/craft resin is usually rated for thin pours only; going beyond it is the most common cause of cracking.
- 2 Pour thick projects in layers, always.** As covered in Section 3, breaking a deep pour into layers lets each layer's heat dissipate before you add the next, instead of one large mass generating heat all at once.
- 3 Keep the room temperature moderate, not hot.** Curing in a hot room (above roughly 80°F / 27°C) or in direct sun adds to the resin's own heat. Aim for the temperature range on your resin's label, typically around 70-75°F (21-24°C).
- 4 Use a resin rated for the job.** A UV resin or a thin craft resin is a poor choice for a thick river or tabletop pour. For anything deeper than a standard pour depth, look for a resin specifically labeled for deep or thick pours and follow its layering instructions.
- 5 Watch for warning signs mid-cure.** If a piece feels distinctly warm to the touch, is visibly smoking, or shows a cloudy "boiling" texture appearing inside it, that layer is overheating — note it for next time and consider thinner layers or a cooler room on your next pour.



Common mistake

Treating "deep pour" as a marketing word instead of a different product. A resin not labeled for deep pours will almost always overheat, yellow, or crack past its stated maximum depth — check the label every time you plan a thick piece, don't assume.

Checklist: before a thick or large pour

- ☐ You've checked your resin's maximum pour depth on the label
- ☐ You have a layering plan if the piece exceeds that depth
- ☐ Room temperature is in the range your resin's label recommends
- ☐ You're using a resin labeled for deep pours if the project calls for one

A quick note on pricing: finished home decor pieces (coasters sets, trays, small art panels) commonly sell in a range of roughly \$20-\$90 depending on size and finish, with small river-style pieces often higher — this is a

rough estimate to help you set a starting price, not a guaranteed number for your own shop.

Next Step

Open **Brand & Packaging Blueprint** next. You now have small jewelry pieces and large decor pieces to sell – that course covers naming your shop, packaging that protects a piece in shipping, and the care cards you hand customers so their resin piece lasts.